

Power Tips for Athlon-based systems



Consider the following steps to build a reliable and high-performance AMD-based system:

Take care while mounting: Processors have a very delicate core as the silicon is exposed on top of the chip. Therefore, great care needs to be taken to ensure that the processor is not damaged by rough and incorrect installation of the heatsink. Ensure that the heatsink is installed flat down, do not try to slide it in, as this could render it useless.

Keep your cool: AMD processors are extremely susceptible to heat problems, and it is critical that they be kept cool. Therefore, the CPU fan has to be plugged in before powering on the system, otherwise the CPU and possibly the motherboard would be damaged within seconds of switching on the system. Also see that the CPU fan is correctly mounted on the system using thermal paste so as to maintain good contact between the heatsink and the processor.

Stick to ratings: Always use a CPU heatsink and fan combination that's been certified by AMD. If you prefer to buy a separate one, make sure it is rated and can run with your particular processor, as Athlon has stringent cooling requirements.

Power considerations: If you plan to use the faster Athlon processors (XP 2000+ and above) along with power-hungry peripherals such as a CD-Writer, large hard disks and a powerful graphics card, use a high-quality power supply with a rating of at least 300 Watts. Most low-end power supplies cannot deliver clean power to systems built on these components, resulting in an unstable system.

Follow the instructions: AMD processors also have specialised instruction sets like 3DNow!, which streamline the power of certain applications. To realise the full potential of these processors, make sure that your applications integrate support for the special instructions. In some cases, you might need to load special patches to enable the support.

Memory matters: AMD processors let you choose between SDRAM and DDR memory. While SDRAM is the cheaper of the two, DDR memory offers higher bandwidths and is continually evolving in terms of technology and speed. SDRAM is a good cost-effective option if you don't plan to run memory-intensive applications. However, DDR's inherent speed and falling prices make it a good investment for the future.

Which processor?: AMD gives you three choices in processors. While the Duron range offers reasonably good performance given its price, it makes sense to choose the Athlons, as Duron processors are on their way out. Here again, you get to choose between the older Palomino processors built around the 0.18-micron process and the new 0.13-micron Thoroughbred core. While the latter boasts higher clock speeds, lower power consumption and consequently better performance, not all motherboards support them. Ensure that your motherboard inherently supports these processors before buying them. Optionally, you could download a BIOS update that would enable the support, if your motherboard allows it.

Don't scrounge: A cheap motherboard will not only ruin your processor, but will also put the stability and reliability of your system at risk. Also, there are plenty of features that a good-quality motherboard allows you in the form of better hardware support, cutting-edge features, even support for overclocking. A branded motherboard will also feature BIOS and driver updates on its Web site.

Drive it in: Ensure that you download and run your AMD motherboard with the latest chipset drivers for high performance—and to eliminate any bugs or compatibility issues. Visit the chipset manufacturer's Web site frequently for driver updates.

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